

Annual Stroke Unit Education Plan

Including Annual Education Calendar — Aligned with AHA/ASA Get With The Guidelines—Stroke and Joint Commission Stroke Center Staff Education Requirements

1. Purpose

This plan defines the stroke program's annual education strategy — target audiences, core curriculum, delivery methods, competency validation, and a month-by-month calendar — to maintain staff readiness, satisfy stroke center certification education requirements, and support consistent, guideline-concordant patient care.

2. Regulatory & Accreditation Basis

- ☐ Certifying bodies (e.g., American Stroke Association International Stroke Center Certification program) require documented, ongoing stroke-specific education for staff caring for stroke patients, with minimum annual contact hours that vary by role and certification level (Acute Stroke Ready, Primary, Thrombectomy-Capable, Comprehensive)
- ☐ New hires complete stroke-specific orientation prior to independently caring for stroke patients; all applicable staff complete annual refresher/competency validation thereafter

Confirm current minimum required contact hours per staff category (RN, physician/APP, EMS, other) against the certifying body's current manual for this facility's certification level — thresholds are updated periodically.

3. Target Audiences

- ☐ Emergency Department nursing and physicians/APPs
- ☐ Stroke unit / Neuro ICU nursing
- ☐ Rehabilitation services: Physical Therapy, Occupational Therapy, Speech-Language Pathology
- ☐ Pharmacy
- ☐ Radiology / CT technologists
- ☐ EMS partner agencies (see institutional EMS–Hospital Stroke Collaboration Agreement)
- ☐ Case Management / Social Work
- ☐ New hires, float pool, and rotating trainees (residents/APP students)
- ☐ Community members (public stroke awareness education)

4. Needs Assessment Process

- ☐ Annual curriculum informed by: stroke registry/performance improvement data gaps (see institutional Stroke Registry Policy), case review findings, new or updated AHA/ASA guideline recommendations, staff competency assessment results, and staff feedback/survey
- ☐ Stroke Committee reviews needs assessment findings and approves the annual curriculum and calendar

5. Core Curriculum Topics

- ☐ Stroke recognition and NIH Stroke Scale (NIHSS) administration and certification
- ☐ Code Stroke activation workflow and roles
- ☐ Dysphagia screening competency
- ☐ IV alteplase (and, if applicable, tenecteplase) high-alert medication preparation and administration safety
- ☐ Mechanical thrombectomy patient selection and post-procedure care
- ☐ Blood pressure and glucose management in acute stroke
- ☐ Early mobilization protocol and fall/aspiration precautions

- ☐ Recognition of complications: hemorrhagic transformation, orolingual angioedema, malignant edema
- ☐ Secondary prevention counseling and discharge/patient education techniques
- ☐ Communication strategies for patients with aphasia, neglect, or cognitive impairment
- ☐ Accurate documentation of registry-required data elements (LKW, times, NIHSS, core measures)
- ☐ Cultural competency and health literacy in patient/family education

6. Delivery Methods

- ☐ Didactic lectures / case-based presentations
- ☐ Online learning modules with post-test
- ☐ Simulation and mock code stroke drills
- ☐ Skills check-off / return demonstration (e.g., dysphagia screen, NIHSS)
- ☐ Multi-station skills fairs
- ☐ Case review / morbidity-mortality-style conferences (non-punitive quality improvement format)
- ☐ Community outreach events and public education campaigns

7. Annual Education Calendar

Illustrative monthly cadence — adjust topics, sequencing, and audience per institutional needs assessment and staffing calendar.

Month	Topic / Focus	Audience	Format	Responsible Party
Jan	Annual stroke program kickoff; prior-year performance review; NIHSS certification renewal	All stroke-designated RNs, Stroke Medical Director	Didactic + online NIHSS module/exam	Stroke Program Coordinator
Feb	Blood pressure & risk factor management in acute stroke (ties to American Heart Month)	ED, stroke unit, ICU nursing	Case-based lecture	Stroke Medical Director
Mar	Acute ischemic stroke recognition & Code Stroke activation workflow	ED nursing, EMS liaisons	Simulation / mock code stroke drill	Stroke Program Coordinator + ED Educator
Apr	Dysphagia screening competency validation	All stroke unit RNs	Skills check-off / return demonstration	Speech-Language Pathology + Nurse Educator
May	National Stroke Awareness Month — public F.A.S.T. campaign; staff refresher on patient/family education tools	Community + all clinical staff	Community outreach events, unit huddles	Stroke Program Coordinator + Community Outreach
Jun	Mechanical thrombectomy: selection criteria & post-procedure care update	Neuro ICU/stroke unit RNs, Neurointerventional team	Didactic + case review	Neurointervention Team + Stroke Medical Director
Jul	New-hire/rotating staff intensive stroke orientation	New hires, float pool, residents/APPs	Orientation module + preceptor-led bedside teaching	Nursing Professional Development + Stroke Coordinator
Aug	IV alteplase high-alert medication safety & administration drill	ED, stroke unit, pharmacy	Simulation with independent double-check practice	Pharmacy + Stroke Program Coordinator
Sep	Early mobilization protocol & fall/aspiration precaution refresher	Stroke unit RNs, PT/OT	Skills workshop	Rehabilitation Services + Nurse Educator
Oct	World Stroke Day (Oct 29) outreach; registry/performance improvement data review with staff	Community + all stroke program staff	Outreach event; PI data huddle	Stroke Program Coordinator
Nov	Nursing competency skills fair: NIHSS, dysphagia screen, code stroke simulation stations	All stroke-designated nursing staff	Multi-station skills fair	Nursing Professional Development
Dec	Annual guideline update review; program evaluation; next-year education plan development	Stroke Committee, Medical Staff, Nursing Leadership	Committee meeting + written summary	Stroke Medical Director + Stroke Program Coordinator

8. Competency Validation & Documentation

- ☐ Completion of each education activity documented in the institutional learning management system / education record for each staff member
- ☐ NIHSS certification tracked with renewal/expiration dates; staff without current certification restricted from independently performing NIHSS assessments per institutional policy
- ☐ Dysphagia screening and other hands-on competencies validated via documented skills check-off, not self-attestation alone
- ☐ Stroke Program Coordinator maintains a master education tracking log for certification survey readiness
- ☐ Non-completion of required annual education addressed per institutional HR/competency policy

9. Evaluation of Education Effectiveness

- ☐ Post-test/knowledge check scores reviewed to assess curriculum effectiveness
- ☐ Competency validation pass rates tracked over time
- ☐ Education outcomes correlated with registry/performance improvement metrics (e.g., door-to-needle time trends, core measure compliance) where feasible
- ☐ Curriculum adjusted annually based on evaluation findings and updated guideline recommendations

10. Roles & Responsibilities

- ☐ Stroke Program Coordinator: develops and maintains the annual plan/calendar, tracks completion, reports to Stroke Committee
- ☐ Nursing Professional Development / Education Department: delivers and documents nursing education activities
- ☐ Stroke Medical Director: reviews and approves clinical content; delivers or co-delivers physician/APP-focused sessions
- ☐ Unit-based stroke champions: reinforce education at the bedside and support peer competency
- ☐ Department leaders (ED, ICU, Rehab, Pharmacy, Radiology): ensure staff attendance/completion within their teams

Plan Approval

Stroke Medical Director: _____ Date: _____

Stroke Program Coordinator: _____ Date: _____

Nursing Professional Development Director: _____ Date: _____

Plan Year: _____ Next Annual Review Date: _____

References: AHA/ASA Get With The Guidelines–Stroke program; American Stroke Association International Stroke Center Certification program Primary/Comprehensive/Thrombectomy-Capable/Acute Stroke Ready Stroke Center certification manuals (staff education and competency requirements); institutional Stroke Registry Policy and Stroke Nursing Care Pathway. This template must be re-verified against the current certifying-body manual and institutional education/HR policy at the time of adoption, as required contact hours and competency standards are updated periodically.